

We've been discussing the free will defense as a response to the argument from evil. This response assumes something about us: that we have free will.

But what does this mean?

To say that we have free will is to say that some of our actions are up to us; it to say that, at least sometimes, we have the ability to choose what we do.

Is it true that some of our actions are up to us, and that we sometimes are able to choose what we will do?

This is the question we'll be asking ourselves for the next two weeks. Our discussion will involve us considering the three strongest arguments **against** the view that we have free will.

But before doing that it is worth asking why there is any reason to accept the common view that we do have free will. Are there any arguments in favor of the reality of free will?

There are. The first argument starts with an apparent fact about moral responsibility: it seems (at least to a first approximation) that we are only responsible for actions which we freely perform. If you find out that someone's action was not done of their own free will, then it would be odd to blame them for their action.

But it also seems that people are at least sometimes genuinely responsible for their actions.

This suggests the following simple argument:

1. If someone's action is not free, then they are not responsible for that action.
2. We are all responsible for at least some of our actions.

C. At least some of our actions are free.

The argument from moral responsibility

How should someone who does not believe in free will respond?

A second argument is similar, and starts from an apparent fact about relationships: genuinely loving relationships of a certain sort must be freely entered into.

This is not true of all loving relationships; for example, the love of a child for a parent is an obvious counterexample. But certain kinds of loving relationships, like those between spouses or friends, seem to require an element of freedom.

But if this is true then we can construct an argument in the obvious way:

THE ARGUMENT FROM LOVING RELATIONSHIPS

1. Certain kinds of loving relationships must be freely entered into.
2. These kinds of loving relationships exist.

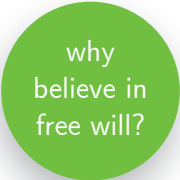
C. People in such relationships exercise free will.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

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that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

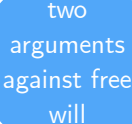
things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a



two
arguments
against free
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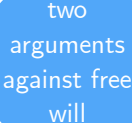
is fate
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three
ways out

freedom that comes from fate.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

responding to Edwards' argument. But

argument might be related to an argument

We'll shortly consider some ways of

first let's think about how Edwards'

for fatalsn.

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

Suppose that someone did not believe in

there were truths about all our future

actions. Could they give an argument

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

similar to Edwards' argument?

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

God only shows up in premises (2) and

with reference to the being of truth about

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

our future actions.



1. We have no direct facts.

2* In the past, there were truths about

perform a certain action (1,2)

will perform various actions.

then we have the choice about q.

that if it is true that I will perform

(3, 4, 5)

5* We have not noticed the fact

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

all of our activities.

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

0 We have achieved what we

some action, then I will prefer that

acaioid.

3 We have not the fact that

God knows that in the future I will



The fatalist argument



The argument from moral responsibility

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